

communications (NFC) enabled mobile device. Further, the token transfer is linked to the shipment of the artwork to ensure a proper transfer of asset and acceptance before the transaction is reflected on the chain,” explains Jothi Krishnan Menon, co-founder & CEO, RtistiQ, an online art marketplace based in Singapore. They use NFTs in the sale of traditional physical art as well as for modern digital art.

Phyigital art: A use case that melds physical and digital art is where a traditional piece of artwork is digitised to extend an artist’s legacy beyond geographical boundaries. RtistiQ ventured to digitise some of Raja Ravi Varma’s privately-held paintings, which are considered national treasures and cannot be taken outside India. A gifted artist, Varma was ahead of his times. He thought that his work should reach everyone and not just the elite, and for that he set up a lithographic press in Mumbai as early as 1894! Raja Ravi Varma’s paintings of Indian gods and goddesses frequently featured on calendars, and it became a habit of the previous generation to carefully frame the pictures at the end of the year to deck up their puja rooms! Today, people across the world have a chance to own NFTs of Raja Ravi Varma’s works.

“At RtistiQ we probably started the reverse order of using NFTs for traditional mediums first, and that has started to gain acceptance as a model to meet some of the existing challenges of the industry. More recently, we have been working on different use cases extended to digital NFTs, to bring forward works of a unique nature, which may not be transactable in the physical form. In the case of the Raja Ravi Varma collection, brought out in collaboration with the Raja Ravi Varma Heritage Foundation, we tried two different models. Two of the paintings, which are privately-held and have been greatly admired, were brought out

Ownership versus copyright

So, when you buy an NFT, what do you get? An NFT is not to be confused with copyright – an NFT only gives you a proof of ownership. There is no copyright transfer, unless explicitly mentioned. You get ownership of the artwork, with licensing terms encoded as metadata along with it. Some creators will let you use your copy only for personal use, while others might permit commercial uses. You will be free to showcase the NFT in a digital or physical gallery and resell it in a secondary marketplace. Some creators may demand a royalty every time someone resells the piece. For example, RTFKT takes a 5% cut of every sale and resale of an avatar, and 10% for all other products including virtual shoes. This is an example of royalties being built into the NFTs.

Since the copyright still exists with the creators, they can create more NFTs based on their art. They can even make more copies of the exact same NFT, but those can only be sold as ‘copies’ as someone has already bought the ‘original.’ There is a tool called CloneMyNFT, which the developers describe as an NFT backup service. It lets the creator keep a copy of the NFT in their wallet even after selling the original. According to the London based software company, “The system works by creating an exact digital copy of the artwork but with another unique contract on the blockchain, effectively making it an almost exact clone of the original NFT. The digital art copy will lack the provenance of the original NFT but will look identical in appearance and could even be sold as a copy.”

“Where the confusion starts is when we mix ownership with copyrights, which are totally independent and governed by what the creator is offering. NFTs in their current form only resolve the ownership aspect of digitised assets, and not essentially the copyrights. As the crypto and blockchain space evolves further we should be seeing decentralised management of copyrights, which then could be linked or encoded with the NFTs instead of just residing as a metadata,” comments Menon.

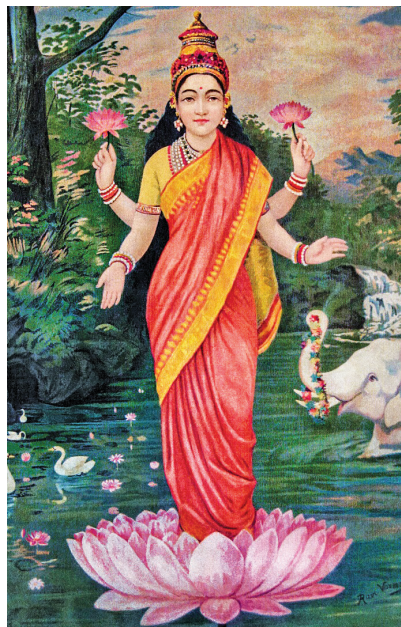


Figure 3: A famous lithograph of Raja Ravi Varma, recreated and auctioned as a combo of digital and physical works (Source: RtistiQ)

by gallery g in Bengaluru, India. Popular lithographs, recreated and embellished for enhancing the works further, were auctioned as a dual-combination of digital and physical works,” explains Menon. In March this year, tokenised versions of Raja Ravi Varma’s works were launched online by RtistiQ in collaboration with the Raja Ravi Varma Heritage Foundation and gallery g.

Recently, they have been helping Ukrainian artists who lost access to their physical paintings due to the war with Russia. They are minting digital editions using available images of the paintings, so the artists can still make a sale of their painstakingly created works. “We are working towards bringing forward more use cases as a combination of traditional and digital mediums for the art community through NFTs, where the original is difficult to